

Figure 1.9 *Blue-glazed, topmost epigraphic bands of* minar*, Sin. © Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*

areas of Balkh, Bamiyan, and ultimately Ghazna, the new rulers largely followed their erstwhile overlords' royal protocols, administration, and patterns of patronage.[48]

The Yamini-Ghaznavids' kingly context included, however, ineluctable specificities such as the material remains of previous political powers and religio-cultural presences. Their co-optation of these pre-existing strata is perhaps best demonstrated in the architectural remains surviving at the royal sites of Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar. The grand palatial architecture there (Figure 1.14) – discussed in detail in Chapter 5 – did not diverge substantially from the non-religious buildings surviving throughout the Persianate world, in fact echoing the courtyard–*ivan* plan at (for example) Robat Sharaf, complete with intimate oratories tucked away within royal ceremonial and reception spaces (Figure 1.12; compared with Lashkari Bazar's South Palace [Chapter 5]). However, monumental *minar*s (Figure 1.15) – towering above the central areas of the capital (Figure 1.14) and frequently encountered in other Afghan regions (cf. above and Chapters 2–4) – were distinct at Ghazna. Rather than the unmistakable "pencil-thin" cylinders marking urban fabrics in the central Saljuq lands,